



Exploring the changing role of brand archetypes in customer-brand relationships: Why try to be a hero when your brand can be more?

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Abstract For over 20 years, managers have been encouraged to leverage archetypal meaning to strengthen their brands. Prior research has studied archetypes as universal patterns present in the collective unconscious that trigger an instinctive response in customers, arguing that brands should evoke one archetype at a time. However, recent evidence seems to suggest that the single archetype view proposed in previous work may have lost its relevance in the marketplace. This article responds to calls for further research into brand archetypes by analyzing more than 2,400 brands and the archetypes they evoke in their marketing communications. The current findings support the continued relevance and importance of brand archetypes in marketing, showing that brands connect with customers by consistently evoking specific archetypes. Critically, however, strong brands tend to leverage multiple archetypes at a time rather than just one as previously believed. We explore key implications of our findings for theory and management, discuss avenues for future research, and provide actionable guidelines for managers wishing to leverage archetypal meaning to build strong brands.

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1. I need a hero

To build successful brands and establish strong customer relationships, managers have been encouraged to use brand archetypes (Ganassali & Matysiewicz, 2021; Woodside, 2010). *Archetypes* are universal patterns that everyone is familiar with, or mental images present in the collective unconscious (i.e., characters that innately exist within the human mind, regardless of culture or geography; Jung, 1959). Because archetypes trigger instinctive responses in customers, they can help marketers tell their brand stories in a form that everyone recognizes and responds to instantly (Megehee & Spake, 2012). Mark and Pearson (2001) were the first to provide a framework that applies the archetypal system to brand management, identifying 12 distinct archetypes that managers can evoke in their branding. For example, when Disney uses the tagline “Where Dreams Come True,” it establishes itself as magical, mysterious, and enchanting. The tagline and related marketing communications provide a clue that is sufficient for consumers’ subconscious minds to tap into a mental library of archetypes (e.g., the Magician) to construct the remainder of Disney’s story.

However, in the 20 years that have passed since Mark and Pearson’s (2001) seminal work, several challenges have emerged. First, the concept of brand archetypes has come under criticism—especially by those tasked with implementing it—for lacking current relevance and practicality in the real world. It is often suggested that brand archetypes are impractical and outdated and that managers do not really know what to do with them (Edwards, 2022; Ritson, 2020). Moreover, scholars such as MacInnis and Folkes (2017, p. 359) have called for further research, noting that “current research on the role of brand archetypes is limited, making this area a fruitful one for understanding how consumers perceive, connect with, and form relationships with brands in human-like ways.”

A second concern is that although prior research has suggested that brand identities are most effective when they identify strongly with one singular archetype (Mark & Pearson, 2001), there is growing evidence that this may no longer be the case. Brands that evoke multiple archetypes have often been analogized to someone afflicted by multiple personality disorder or dissociative identity disorder, and the term “brand schizophrenia” is sometimes used (e.g., Tahmasebifard & Kheiri, 2018). However, an alternative view is that

brands can successfully blend different archetypes (Wertime, 2002). For instance, recent research has shown that strong brands often evoke multiple archetypes at the same time (Xara-Brasil et al., 2018). The world in which brands compete has changed dramatically since the early work on brand archetypes, and the emergence of new channels and technologies allows modern brands to use a wider, richer range of touchpoints to connect with customers and tell their stories (Baxendale et al., 2015). Customers want relevant, authentic brands that seem to have nothing to hide (Liu et al., 2015; Merlo et al., 2018). Brands are also becoming increasingly democratized, as the internet and social media have empowered customers to take over brands’ narratives (Asmussen et al., 2013). As such, a critical question remains as to whether brands should devote resources in attempts to evoke one single archetype.

Considering this, our article has two key objectives. First, it aims to explore whether, in the current market environment, brands use archetypes strategically to connect with customers and, if so, how they do it and whether it is done in a focused way or via multiple simultaneous archetypes. Second, if the concept of brand archetypes is indeed still relevant today, we aim to identify practical implementation guidelines for theory and managers. To achieve these objectives, we collected data from more than 2,400 brands and analyzed the archetypes evoked in their marketing communications. In Sections 2 and 3, we discuss the theoretical background and methodology. We then discuss our findings, examine implications for theory and management, and conclude with avenues for future research in Sections 4–7.

2. Theoretical background

2.1. Brand archetypes and customer-brand relationships

The concept of psychological archetypes was pioneered by the psychiatrist Carl Jung (1959) in his study of cultural mythologies. Jung observed that across different cultures, common characters tend to be featured in myths and legends. These are based on unconscious, innate images that we all have from birth. He called them *archetypes*, which he defined as “forms or images of a collective nature which occur practically all over the earth as constituents of myths and at the same time as individual products of unconscious origin.” For example, the understanding of the Mother

archetype (e.g., as nurturing, caring, and reliable) is so deep and universal that it can even describe nonhuman concepts (e.g., mother nature, mother ships, the mother country; [Spangenberg, 2021](#)). Therefore, the Mother archetype has been used extensively in marketing—such as P&G’s successful Thank You, Mom campaign, which exemplifies the power of great storytelling and archetypal myths in branding.

Previous research has suggested that when used in marketing, archetypes can act as shortcuts for consumers to build an emotional attachment to brands ([Lindstrom, 2008](#); [Woodside, 2010](#); [Zaltman, 2003](#)). More specifically, it may be sufficient for a brand to provide a small cue associated with an archetype so an individual’s subconscious mind can piece together the remaining elements of the narrative ([Vincent, 2002](#)). Because most consumer decisions may occur in the subconscious ([Lindstrom, 2008](#)), the instinctive connection made with a brand archetype—through its claim to fulfill a basic human desire—can greatly benefit the brand ([Zaltman, 2003](#)). Brand elements, therefore, become like props and building blocks of brand-consumer relationships ([Muniz et al., 2015](#); [Woodside et al., 2008](#)). And when brands evoke archetypes effectively, they can improve brand recognition, brand preference, and propensity to buy ([Woodside, 2010](#)).

Because archetypes are universal, present in all of us from birth, and “as natural and embedded in us as our DNA” ([Haddad et al., 2015](#), p. 23), they may help brands resonate across cultures. As the psychic counterpart of instinct, they can trigger automatic emotional reactions in consumers ([Faber & Mayer, 2009](#)). Today, brands can no longer differentiate themselves purely based on functional attributes, so building a connection with customers via brand meaning and personality has become increasingly important for standing out in a crowded market. Brands may evoke archetypes using different touchpoints such as websites, advertisements, content marketing, symbols, experiences, colors, or logos ([Aaker, 1996](#)). As prior studies have shown, customers are attracted to stories and brand personalities that satisfy their needs and reinforce their self-concept in society, which can create a self-brand connection ([Escalas & Bettman, 2005](#); [Park et al., 2013](#)). In turn, these brand personalities can differentiate the brand from competitors and enhance marketing effectiveness, brand equity, and profitability ([Keller, 1993](#); [Levy, 1985](#); [Park et al., 2016](#)).

To date, brand archetypes in marketing have been categorized in several different ways.

Drawing on Jungian psychology and the four universal human desires—*independence, belonging, stability, and mastery*—[Mark and Pearson \(2001\)](#) identified 12 distinct archetypes. The Innocent, the Explorer, and the Sage are associated with independence, driven by the pursuit of happiness; the Hero, the Outlaw, and the Magician are about mastery, representing those who want to change the world around them; the Caregiver, the Creator, and the Ruler are associated with stability and helping people feel more secure; and the Everyman, the Lover, and the Jester are about belonging and people’s need to connect with others. These archetypes can facilitate brand stories, create brand meaning, and build emotional connections with customers ([Holt & Thompson, 2004](#)). [Mark and Pearson \(2001\)](#) demonstrated that associating a brand with an archetype—such as Coca-Cola with the Innocent archetype or Nike with the Hero—can have a significant impact on the real asset valuation of a company. Importantly, they also argued that a single archetype must act as a brand’s “beacon” for the corresponding human motivation and that brands should evoke only one archetype for simplicity and recognizability.

However, an alternative view to the single archetype thesis suggests that brands can make several connections with customers at the same time. According to [Wertime \(2002, p. 215\)](#), “strong brands often harmonize multiple subconscious elements,” and “the decision about which archetype(s) to associate with a brand provides plenty of room for creativity and requires the company to think about how the archetypes will work in combination.” A recent study in several Spanish-speaking countries ([Xara-Brasil et al., 2018](#)) showed that the Apple brand evokes a multiplicity of archetypes in the minds of consumers: the Creator, Sage, and Ruler. In addition, Facebook was seen as a combination of the Jester, Everyman, and Ruler, while Amazon evoked a combination of the Sage, Creator, Ruler, and Caregiver. Another study ([Haddad et al., 2015](#)) found that the Nike brand also evokes a combination of archetypes, such as the Hero and the Rebel. Brands seem to use multiple archetypes to make their stories richer and more attractive, leading to long-lasting performance ([Molinillo et al., 2017](#)).

3. Research methodology

The key objectives of our research were to investigate if brands tend to evoke specific archetypes consistently in their marketing communications—if so, how—and to what extent their

approach is focused or involves a blend of multiple simultaneous archetypes. To do so, our methodology was divided into two steps.

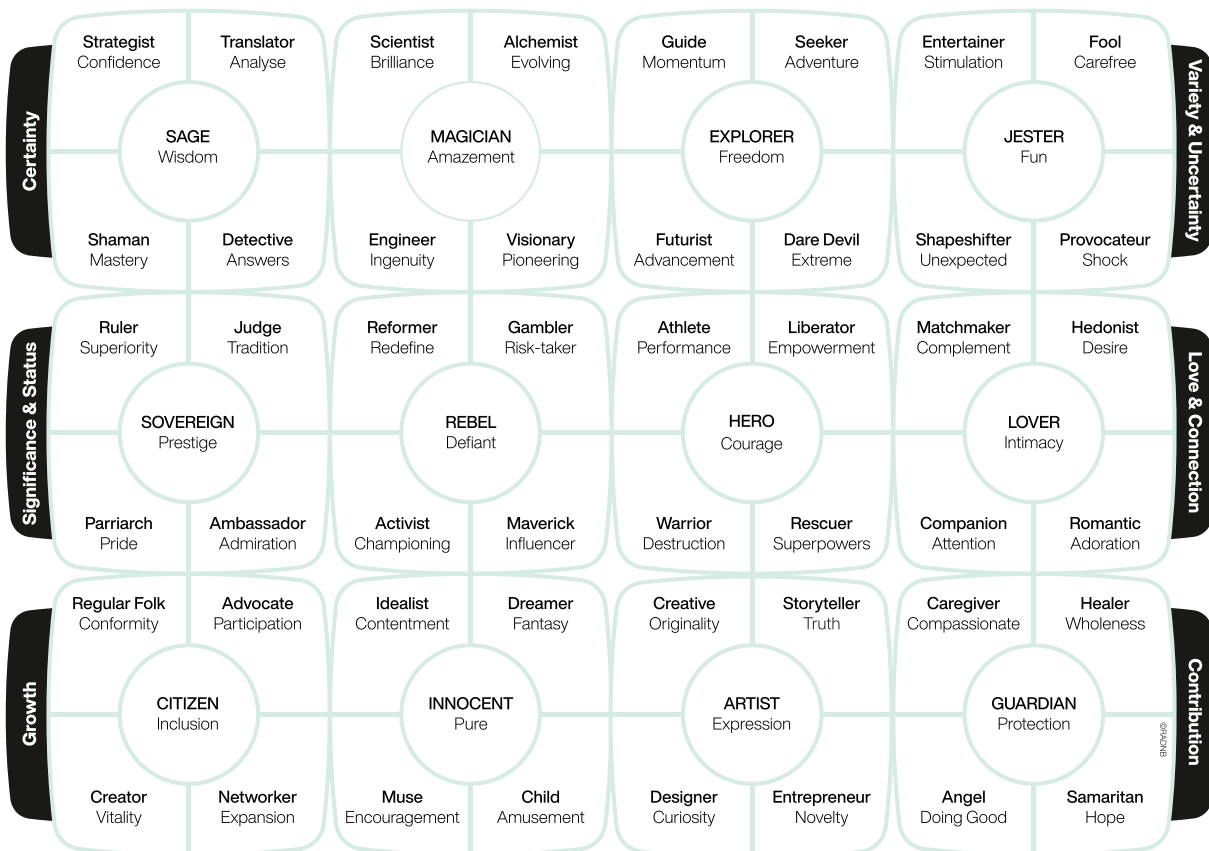
3.1. Research methodology: Step one

In the first step, we placed the 12 primary archetypes identified by [Mark and Pearson \(2001\)](#) on a 3×4 matrix according to the human needs to which they relate. We used three levels of core human needs drawing on [Maslow's \(1943\)](#) hierarchy of needs theory and its later refinement by [Alderfer \(1989\)](#): the Existence, Relatedness, and Growth (ERG) theory of motivation. The latter theory—which has strong empirical support (e.g., [Robbins & Judge, 2008](#); [Schneider & Alderfer, 1973](#))—is particularly useful because it acknowledges that individuals are motivated by a simultaneous combination of needs rather than a progressive hierarchy. In addition, different individuals prioritize their needs in different orders based on their own attitudes and personality. In accordance with [Alderfer \(1989\)](#), the 3×4 archetypes matrix depicts three main categories of needs and their associated dichotomies:

1. *Existence needs*: certainty (i.e., the need for safety, stability, and control) vs. uncertainty (i.e., the need for the unknown, change, and surprise).
2. *Relatedness needs*: significance and status (the need to have meaning, importance, and being wanted) vs. love and connection (the need for attachment, intimacy, and connection).
3. *Growth needs*: growth (the need for personal development) vs. contribution (the need to help, serve, and support others).

By depicting [Mark and Pearson's \(2001\)](#) 12 brand archetypes as a matrix, we obtain a visual representation of the spectrum of human emotional needs and how they relate to each of the archetypes. Next, we followed [Hartwell and Chen's \(2012\)](#) suggestion that each of the 12 brand archetypes has within it a family of four archetypes. As such, our analysis led to a matrix depicting 60 archetypes related to the core human needs (see [Figure 1](#)). This allows for as much granularity as possible in our analysis and

Figure 1. Mapping the brand archetypes



more detail in the next step of our methodology: the coding and mapping process, as discussed in Section 3.2.

3.2. Research methodology: Step two

In the second stage of our methodology, we employed an iterative coding process whereby visual elements (e.g., online campaigns, websites, brochures, advertisements) of more than 2,400 brands were hand-coded by five industry and academic experts in brand management, consumer psychology, and storytelling techniques over a period of three years. Inter-coder agreement on how these visual elements mapped onto the 60 archetypes was high (> 78%), and the remaining cases were resolved based on discussion among the team of coders. We analyzed brands of different sizes from all over the world and across a wide range of industries, including B2C and B2B. In total, we examined 14,527 brand images, including both online and offline marketing communications used by the focal brands. In our analyses, we were deliberately nonselective and avoided choosing brands that merely had big marketing budgets and were probably the most proficient at using archetypes (e.g., the most famous brands). That is, we aimed to obtain and examine a diverse selection of creative styles and mapped both good creative designs and poor ones. To make the mapping representative of brands in general, the brands selected were international and local, had large, medium, and small budgets, and came from multiple sectors.

4. General findings and discussion

Our findings reveal that brands do appear to evoke specific archetypes strategically and consistently in their marketing communications. Clear patterns emerge when we analyzed brands' visual elements, suggesting that archetypes are not evoked at random but are part of deliberate strategies to connect with customers emotionally in specific ways. The most popular primary archetypes were the Detective (11%), Advocate (8%), Sage (5%), Visionary (5%), and Engineer (4%). Importantly, we found that most brands, including some of the world's best-performing brands, evoke multiple archetypes at the same time. Less than 2% of the brands in the dataset had a consistent association with only one archetype, and most brands evoked at least two or three archetypes in their marketing communications. In Table 1, we list the archetypes used by some of the most valuable brands in the world according to the Interbrand (2022)

brand valuation method, and in Table 2, we list the most common combinations of archetypes emerging from the data.

While Nike was often seen as centered around the Hero archetype (e.g., Mark & Pearson, 2001), our data indicate that nowadays, its storytelling is more complex. First, to make its story more compelling, Nike makes the customer—rather than the brand—the hero (i.e., the one who is encouraged to “Just Do It”). Second, Nike counterbalances the potentially negative associations of the Hero archetype (e.g., aggression and arrogance) by embedding other archetypes into its narratives, such as the Angel, Provocateur, Reformer, and Activist (see Figure 2). The result is a complex, multilayered story that makes the brand unique and distinctive. In the same way, Harley-Davidson was traditionally considered a brand anchored solely on the Outlaw archetype. However, our analysis reveals a brand that is not monolithic but crafts a complex and rather surprising story, which weaves several different and unexpected archetypes together (see Figure 3).

Since its famous 1971 campaign I'd Like to Buy the World a Coke, Coca-Cola has talked about uniting the world and bringing people together by evoking a combination of the Citizen and the Matchmaker archetypes. Their latest Real Magic campaign—launched in 2021, which promises to unite and uplift people every day—still demonstrates the same core archetypes, yet adding the Hero, Warrior, and Magician (see Figure 4). This enables the brand to create more diverse content for a global market than was required in 1971. As Coca-Cola's CMO states, “Coca-Cola is a brand defined by dichotomies: humble but iconic, authentic yet secret, real yet magical...The Real Magic philosophy is rooted in the belief that dichotomies can make the world a more interesting place” (The Coca-Cola Company, 2021, p. 1). These dichotomies at the heart of the brand are expressed effectively by creating tension via multiple archetypes, rather than by trying to evoke only a single archetype.

5. Theoretical implications

This article contributes to the literature on brand personality and customer-brand relationships (Escalas & Bettman, 2005; Keller, 1993; MacInnis & Folkes, 2017; Park et al., 2016). One provocative finding of this research is that focusing on multiple archetypes can lead to a rich brand narrative without negative outcomes (e.g., brand dilution, weakness, or confusion). Contrary to previous research (Mark & Pearson, 2001; Tahmasebifard & Kheiri, 2018), our findings show

Table 1. Archetypes evoked by the world's most valuable brands

Brand	1 st Archetype	2 nd Archetype	3 rd Archetype	4 th Archetype
Apple	Visionary (Pioneering) 15%	Engineer (Ingenuity) 11%	Magician (Amazement) 10%	Shaman (Mastery) 7%
Amazon	Advocate (Participation) 12%	Seeker (Adventure) 10%	Visionary (Pioneering) 8%	Hedonist (Desire) 6%
Microsoft	Sage (Wisdom) 22%	Citizen (inclusion) 18%	Visionary (Pioneering) 16%	Engineer (Ingenuity) 9%
Google	Engineer (Ingenuity) 26%	Muse (Encouragement) 16%	Citizen (inclusion) 9%	Visionary (Pioneering) 8%
Samsung	Engineer (Ingenuity) 21%	Gambler (Risk-taker) 16%	Explorer (Freedom) 10%	Provocateur (Shock) 9%
Coca Cola	Matchmaker (Complement) 21%	Liberator (Empowerment) 10%	Advocate (Participation) 7%	Innocent (Pure) 5%
Toyota	Liberator (Empowerment) 14%	Athlete (Performance) 10%	Seeker (Adventure) 7%	Dare Devil (Extreme) 7%
Mercedes-Benz	Sovereign (Prestige) 15%	Sage (Wisdom) 12%	Ruler (Superiority) 11%	Visionary (Pioneering) 11%
McDonald's	Matchmaker (Complement) 40%	Storytelling (Truth) 18%	Companion (Attention) 7%	Rescuer (Superpowered) 5%
Disney	Magician (Amazement) 36%	Visionary (Pioneering) 16%	Companion (Attention) 15%	Sovereign (Prestige) 13%
Nike	Hero (Courage) 39%	Liberator (Empowerment) 8%	Reformer (Redefine) 7%	Designer (Curiosity) 6%
BMW	Athlete (Performance) 16%	Guardian (Protection) 12%	Provocateur (Shock) 9%	Explorer (Freedom) 7%
Tesla	Engineer (Ingenuity) 28%	Shaman (Mastery) 24%	Ruler (Superiority) 8%	Seeker (Adventure) 6%

Source: [Interbrand \(2022\)](#)

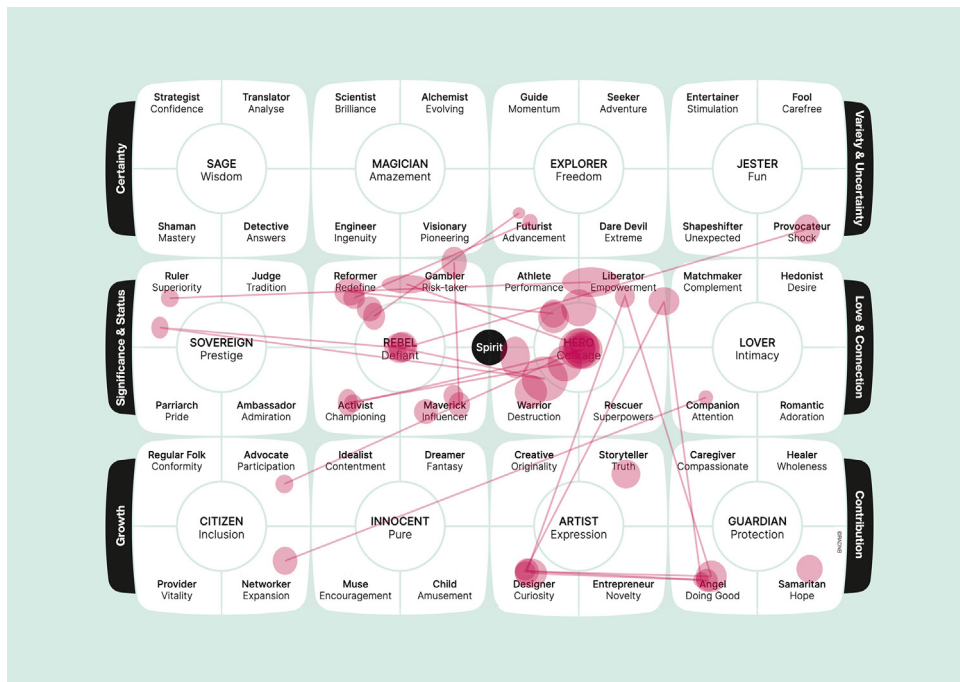
Table 2. Most prevalent combinations of brand archetypes

Combination	Meaning	Incidence	Example
Advocate & Detective	Solutions + Participation <i>"We have solutions that help you do the things you want to"</i>	631 (26.5%) ^a p/s=52 ^b	Zurich
Engineer & Detective	Ingenuity + Solutions <i>"We put together clever solutions that work"</i>	370 p/s=10	QuickBooks
Angel & Advocate	Doing Good + Participation <i>"What you do helps you and others"</i>	364 p/s=13	Aviva
Muse & Detective	Encouragement + Solution <i>"We help you easily find answers"</i>	290 p/s=7	Hootsuite
Guide & Shaman	Momentum + Mastery <i>"We are experts in helping you move forward with certainty and purpose"</i>	287 p/s=4	Clyde & Co
Visionary & Engineer	Pioneering + Ingenuity <i>"Future solutions"</i>	253 p/s=14	Apple
Sage & Citizen	Wisdom + Inclusion <i>"We have the wisdom of a diverse population and global planet"</i>	211 p/s=12	EY

^a Total number of brands (and percentage of brands) evoking these archetypes in combination

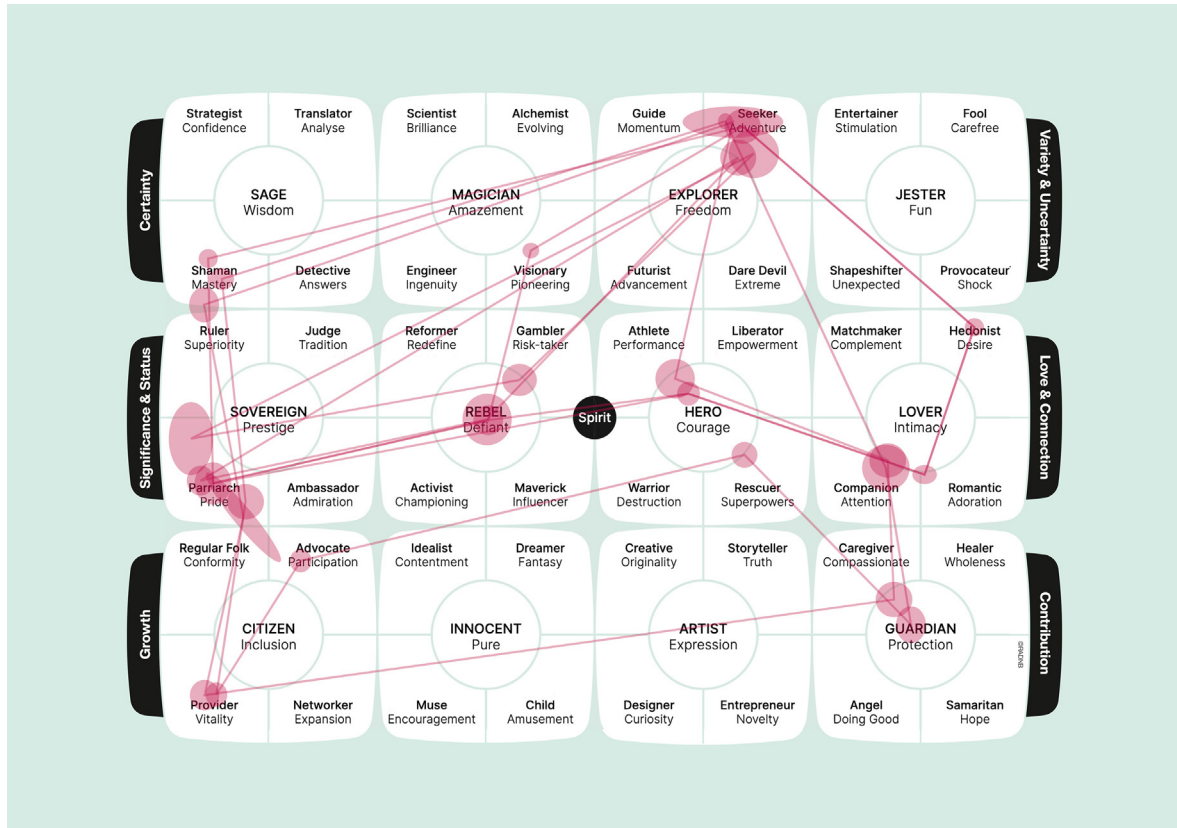
^b Number of brands evoking this combination of archetypes in that specific order as the primary and secondary archetypes

Figure 2. The archetypes of Nike



*Note: The shape and size of the circles denote the area on the map each image occupies. The volume of the area denotes the strength of that (archetypal) emotional driver. The location denotes the proximity and or overlap, with any neighboring (archetypal) emotional drivers.

Figure 3. The archetypes of Harley Davidson



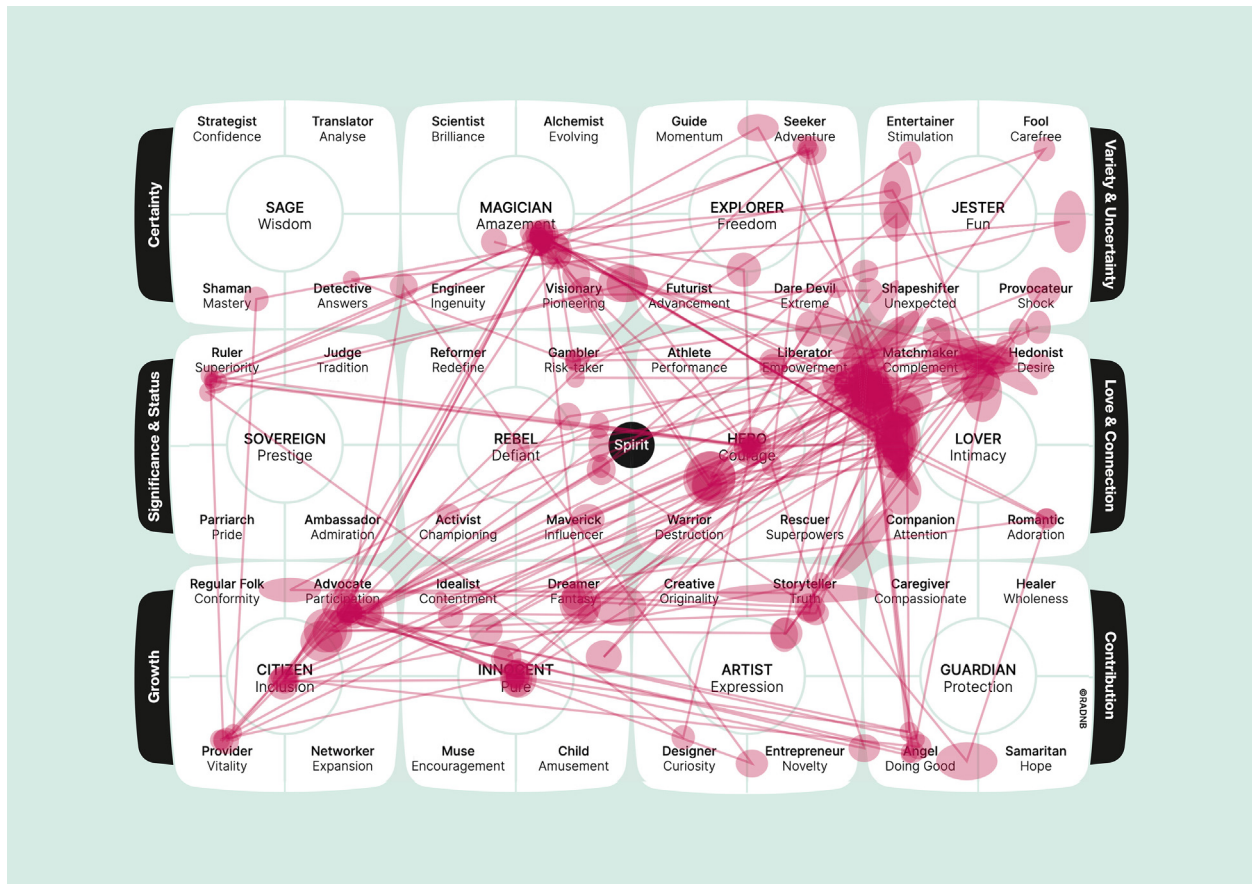
that not only are some of the brands that evoke multiple archetypes among the strongest and most valuable in the world but also they are some of the fastest growing. Consider Tesla, for example, which is the fastest-growing brand in [Interbrand's \(2022\)](#) valuation, with an estimated 184% increase in its brand value from the previous year. Our findings suggest that the brand evokes the Engineer and Shaman archetypes to equal degrees—plus the Ruler and Seeker to a lesser extent—which conveys a rich and resonant story (i.e., “we have cleverly and purposefully brought the best we can to free you from your life’s challenges”). We observed similar patterns in many other fast-growing brands, both in B2C and B2B.

Furthermore, this study extends current knowledge by highlighting how brands may take advantage of various customer touchpoints and their proliferation. It is indeed possible that the emergence of new channels and technologies ([Dholakia et al., 2010](#))—as well as a trend toward more inclusive marketing ([Park et al., 2022](#))—have encouraged brands to use a wider range of touchpoints, tell richer stories, and appeal to a more diverse set of customers. Today, the best-crafted brand stories seem to comprise multiple

archetypes. It is plausible that the single brand archetype argument made sense in a world with limited touchpoints, which required marketers to maximize the effectiveness of their messages in the few opportunities available to connect with their audiences. But today, brands can tell fuller stories, which are increasingly told using multiple channels and cocreated with a broad and diverse group of customers ([Labrecque, 2014](#)). For example, while Coca-Cola used its original 1971 TV advertisement for several years, in just one year since the 2021 launch of Real Magic, they have already created nearly 200 different videos on social media.

While traditional advertisements required a compelling and focused message—as well as repetition—to break through the clutter ([Aaker, 1996](#)), today brands’ stories are created and cocreated using a myriad of channels: blogs, social media sites, immersive experiences, video platforms, and virtual reality. The story is decreasingly controlled by the brand, and complex, diverse narratives can emerge. The richer the blend, the more audiences can interpret, find, and construct their unique story and meaning within the brand’s story. A brand that builds a narrative involving different archetypes allows a diverse group of customers to choose what

Figure 4. The archetypes of Coca-Cola



parts of that narrative are most relevant to them. Either their specific need or personality/mood at that moment may draw their attention to one aspect of the brand over another. A good story can also attract and retain attention by developing tension during the narrative (Muniz et al., 2015; Woodside et al., 2008; Zak, 2014)—and multiple archetypes may provide that tension. The current study holds critical implications for managers, which we discuss in Section 6.

6. Managerial implications

Our findings address concerns about the applicability of the concept of brand archetypes and highlight five practical guidelines for managers.

6.1. Layer multiple archetypes to maintain customers' attention

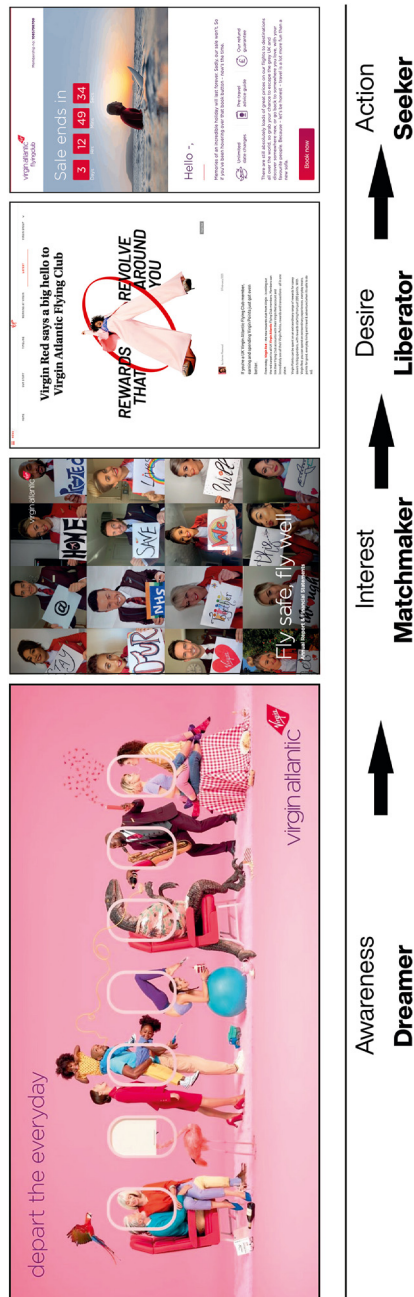
First, our findings suggest that some of the best brands do not reveal all archetypes they evoke at once but layer them together across the customer journey, each adding another layer of interper-

etation (e.g., via different pages on a website, rolling banners, or different campaigns spread over time). Brands can benefit by catering to different customer needs across the customer journey. For example, a brand wishing to attract attention and introduce its products to new customers may use the Jester or Hero archetypes to get their attention. However, to hold that attention and ultimately win customers' business and loyalty, the brand may want to rely on the Sage or Guardian archetypes. Critically, brands must be clear on what story to tell at which point of the customer journey. Virgin Atlantic, for instance, evokes the more extreme Dreamer archetype to stand out (see Figure 5). Then, via promotional offers, they evoke the Seeker archetype. Finally, to cross-sell, reignite interest, and communicate its corporate and social responsibility, it uses archetypes like the Liberator or Matchmaker.

6.2. Reveal brands slowly across different touchpoints to cultivate intimacy

Historically, brands needed to stand out straight away and did so by using one archetype in a

Figure 5. Virgin Atlantic's storytelling along the customer journey



conspicuous and consistent way. This occasionally caused them to come across as loud, pushy, and “shouting” in tone. Today, brands can try to make customers feel like they have discovered them, making the brand feel more personal. For example, Peloton—the global exercise equipment and media company—uses the Hero and Athlete archetypes aligned with the Regular Folk archetype. To diversify, they blend in archetypes like the Entertainer, Maverick, Angel, and Guardian. One example is their Comeback campaign, in which people from different walks of life who have overcome major challenges are gifted a bike. This creates a combination that allows people to at once find their tribe, write their comeback story, and connect with archetypes that reflect their needs (see Figure 6).

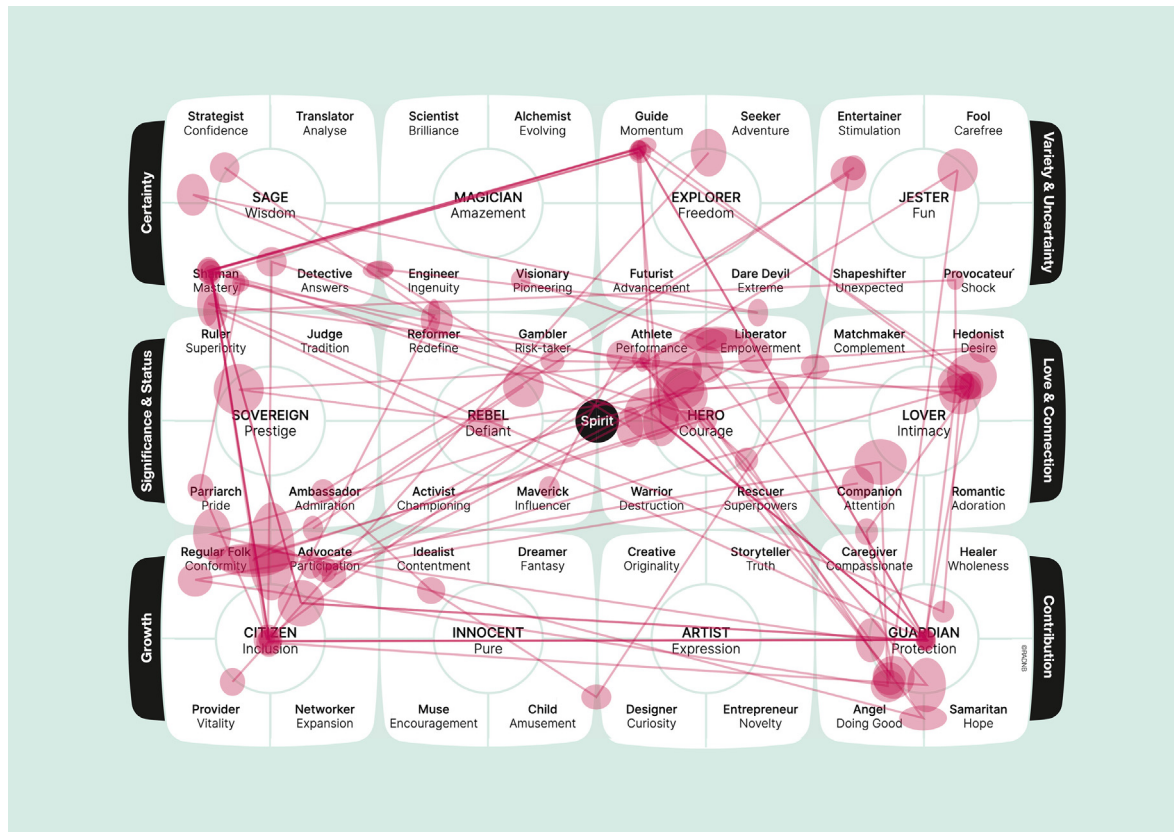
6.3. Strong brands craft stories based on patterns with natural tension

We find that brands can leverage natural tensions by cleverly evoking contrasting archetypes in their storytelling—without overstressing the brand. In doing so, they can stand out and create something distinctive and compelling. In Dove’s version of their response to the now infamous Protein World campaign Beach Body Ready, we see a brand taking head on the idea of tension. In Dove’s case, this tension and conflict emerge from the portrayal of women with “ideal” perceptions or figures. Dove evokes various archetypes within this one campaign to express such different underlying tensions, leveraging two opposing sides of the map: the need for love and connection versus the need for significance. In this campaign, women are shown as both strong, individual leaders as well as powerful friends (see Figure 7).

6.4. Brands evoke multiple, harmonious archetypes

Some combinations of archetypes are prevalent and work particularly well because they lead to harmonious storytelling. For example, the Sage archetype is synergistic with the Strategist and Detective, as they overlap. Archetypes like the Jester and the Maverick coincide less, if at all, while some opposing archetypes like the Lover and the Creative occasionally work together. This is because certain stories require certain combinations, and each archetype brings its own narrative, values, feelings, and needs to a story. Some combinations of brand archetypes are so prevalent that dominant patterns have emerged within given sectors, allowing us to identify brands that

Figure 6. The archetypes of Peloton



either conform or differentiate themselves. In the business consulting sector, for example, most narratives are built around the primary need for “certainty,” as expressed through members of the Sage family (top left). As we now recognize, however, brands do not evoke single archetypes for various reasons, primarily because their brand needs—and is able—to craft more complex narratives. What we found with brands like Deloitte, McKinsey & Company, EY, KPMG, and PWC (see Figure 8) is an alignment to an overall sector narrative. The common narrative is: “We provide intelligent solutions that guide you to a positive future in an ever-changing global market.” To tell this narrative, they evoke members of the Sage family, the Citizen, and various combinations of the Visionary and Guide archetypes. Accenture, while covering similar archetypes and touching upon the same sector narrative, emphasizes the search for visionary and creative solutions. Thus, its primary archetype is the Visionary, which it frequently blends—in a unique combination within the sector—with the Creative archetype. We have found similar patterns in other sectors, such as the automotive industry, which uses Engineer/Shaman

and the Engineer/Visionary as the top two archetypal combinations, with only a few brands differentiating (e.g., Land Rover with Explorer/Seeker, Jeep with Explorer/Entrepreneur, Jaguar with Ruler/Athlete, and Alfa Romeo with Athlete/Lover).

6.5. Archetypes help brands tell a story

Finally, archetypes mold stories crafted by brands. Each position on the archetypes matrix represents a different narrative and the emotional needs a brand can meet. The following practical steps can help managers evoke specific archetypes, define their brand’s narrative and competitive positioning, and deliver the brand more effectively across the customer journey. First, managers should assess the main narrative approaches present in competitors’ brand messages (Figure 9). What are the driving emotional needs the brands are trying to communicate? In addition to the primary needs on the left and right sides of the matrix, the labels at the top and bottom of the framework also provide further guidance to map images. The archetypes in the top left are

Figure 7. The archetypes of Dove

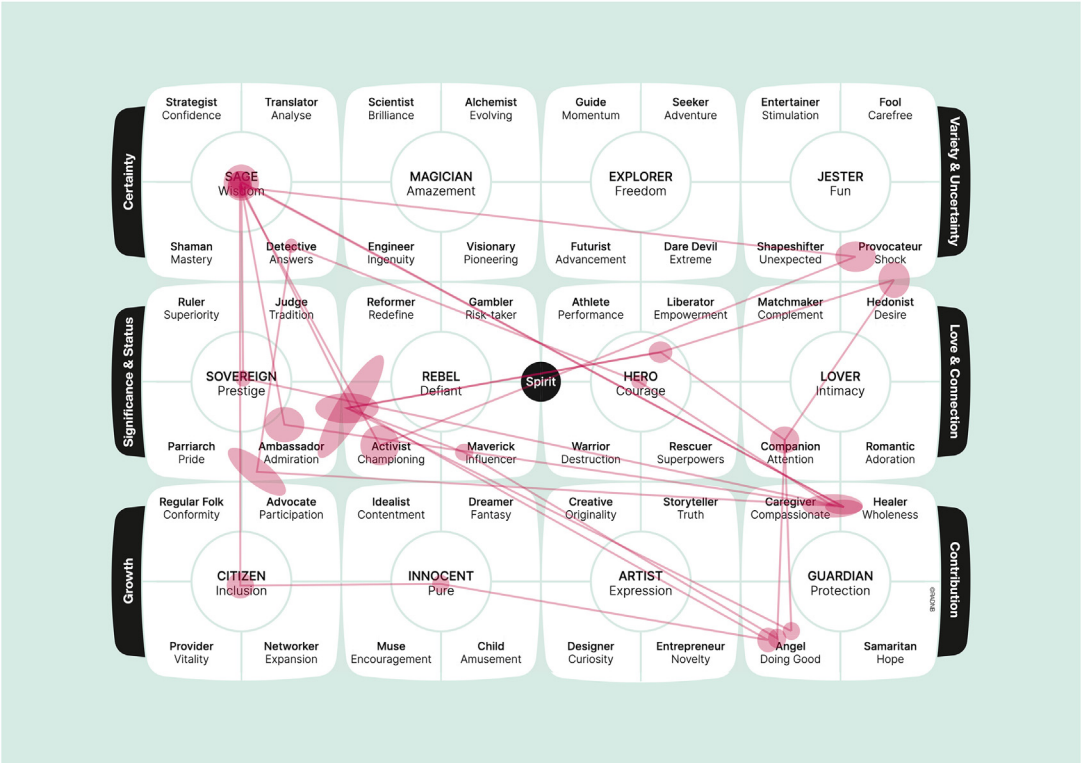


Figure 8. The archetypes of selected consulting firms

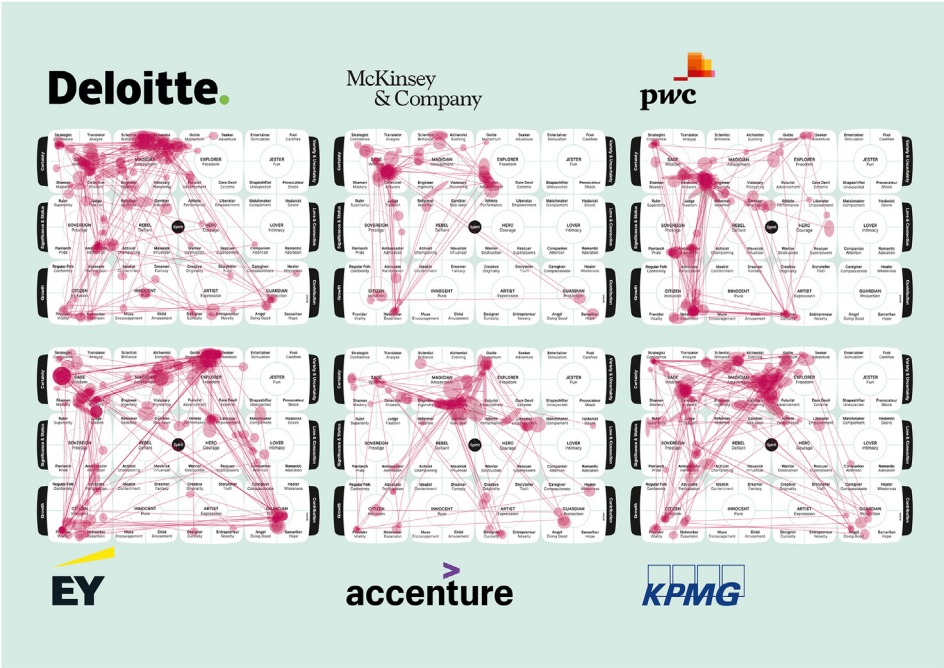
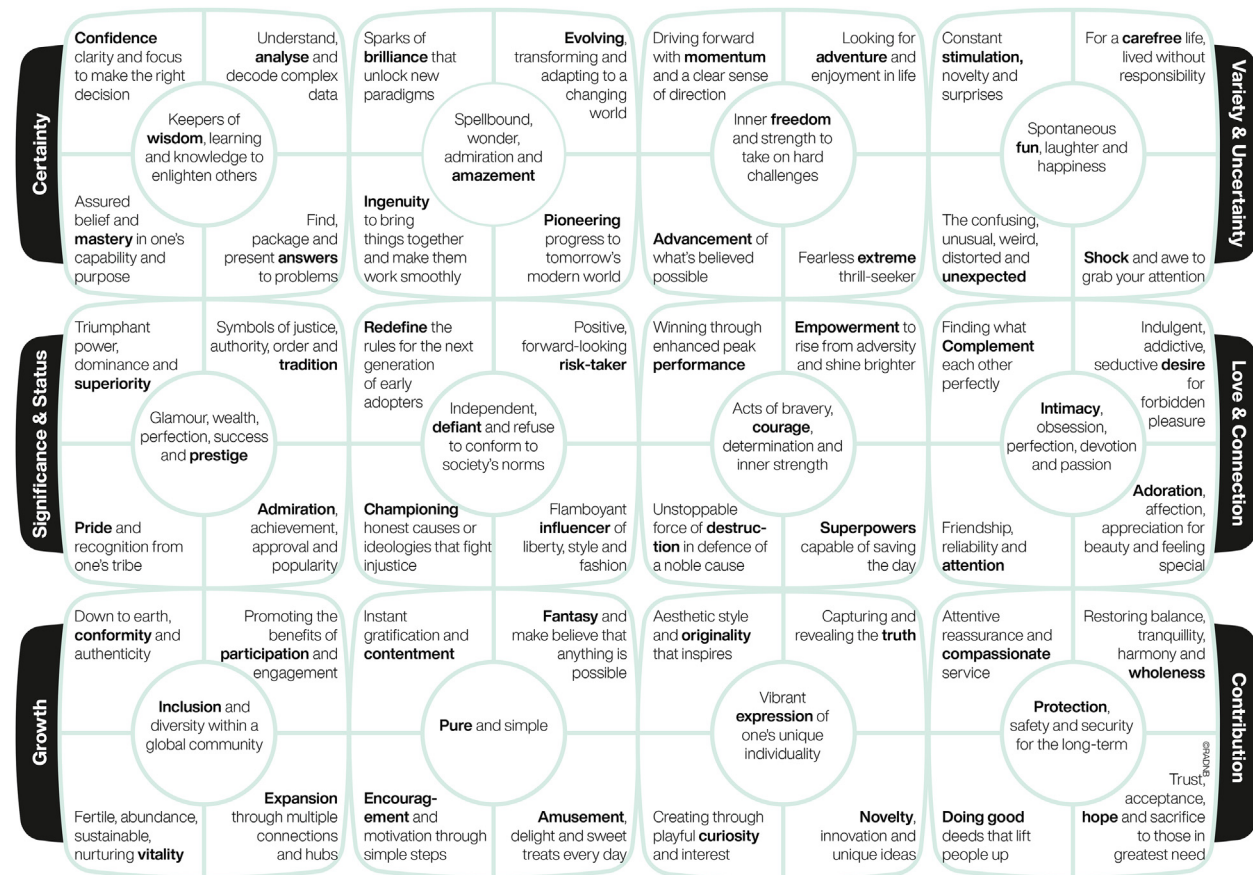


Figure 9. Brand archetypes narratives



frequently evoked by depicting control and excellence, the top right ones through challenge and excitement, the bottom left ones through collaboration and play, and the bottom right ones through imagination and responsibility. Brands benefit from going through this process more than once to identify the dominant needs that resonate in the brand's communications.

Once main competitors are mapped, managers should go through the same process for their own brands, analyzing the emotional drivers in their communications. Once managers have mapped where the brand is against the competition, they may see some natural areas of overlap, which tend to reflect sector needs (e.g., many life insurance brands eventually use the Guardian or Guide archetypes to reflect the need for protection or investment guidance). Then, using the spectrum of emotional drivers, managers can explore the relevance of different archetypes via strategic reviews and workshops. When coupled with research data about market opportunities and

customers' needs and preferences, combinations of archetypes may be explored to provide the most potential for brand growth, leading to a single narrative from all the individual narratives each location or archetype represents. We have provided several examples of how brands such as Nike, Virgin Atlantic, Harley Davidson, and Peloton have crafted rich stories that evoke multiple archetypes and define their narratives. Managers can merge multiple archetypes into the same message (e.g., one specific advertisement or social media campaign) or tell different stories across different campaigns or touchpoints (e.g., evoke an archetype on print media and another in online display advertising). Figure 9 provides guidelines in terms of the message content and tone that can be used. Finally, instead of telling the whole story in one go, it may be beneficial to develop the narrative over time across the stages of the purchase funnel. The archetypes used to stand out and draw attention at the awareness stage may be very different from those used to build desire or action.

Figure 10. Examples of brand archetypes across the customer journey

Awareness	Interest	Desire	Action
This stage typically requires campaigns designed to grab people's attention. So 'louder' archetypes from the top right quartile of the matrix are often used, as they have higher levels of energy and emotion that makes them naturally stand out.	This stage usually involves providing evidence in support of claims made by the brand. Therefore, archetypes that feel reassuring, strong, and confident are more often used, reflected by the qualities of the archetypes in top left quartile of the matrix.	In this stage, creating tension often helps, for example between internal personal forces, such as 'I want this but...'. Extreme blends of archetypes, from opposing areas of the needs map, are more often used.	This stage requires facilitating clear and easy next steps. Thus, archetypes such as those found in the bottom left quartile are frequently used to promote for example 'how easy and simple it is to get benefits so many others enjoy'.
Examples			
In the fast-food industry, brands often use the Matchmaker and Entertainer to offer you new and exciting food combinations. This along with the Advocate/Idealist tell you they are the 'Perfect Combination'. The Jester is also often used to get attention.	In large corporate consultancies where risk planning is critical, a narrative of advice that guides you through difficult times is often told through combinations of the Strategist/Shaman with the Alchemist/Guide. The Visionary can also help build desire.	In the automotive and fashion industry, combinations of the Sovereign, Rebel and Hedonist are regularly used to support a narrative of 'you're special, you're worth it'.	In the consumer financial services sector, especially mutuals and building societies, the Advocate, Regular Folk, and Ambassadors combined with the Detective offer solutions to the lifestyle you want (and often, which others have).

Individual pieces of communication can have different roles and tones across the journey, as outlined in Figure 10.

7. Opportunities for future research

The current study points to promising avenues for future research. While we found that successful brands frequently employ a combination of different archetypes for stronger, more meaningful customer-brand relationships, additional research could further explore how a brand's positioning remains relevant given a certain Zeitgeist. In addition, specific archetypes resonate differently depending on the target customer group, so future research might examine the strengths and weaknesses of the various archetypes—and their combinations—in connecting with different customer groups effectively, regardless of their conditions. Further research could also explore whether—and, if so, at what point—evoking several archetypes at the same time may dilute a brand's message. While we found that some of the best-performing brands evoke multiple archetypes simultaneously, most of them still tend to rely on a relatively parsimonious number of archetypes, such as four or five. It is plausible that a curvilinear (i.e., inverted-U) relationship may exist between building tension in a brand's storytelling by evoking additional archetypes and brand equity. This could be a fruitful direction for future research. Finally, as new technologies and channels offer additional avenues for brands to reach out to customers to tell their brand stories in the future (e.g., artificial intelligence, robotics, virtual/augmented reality, and the metaverse), additional research could explore how new channels may shape how effectively different archetypes enhance consumers' connections with a brand.

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